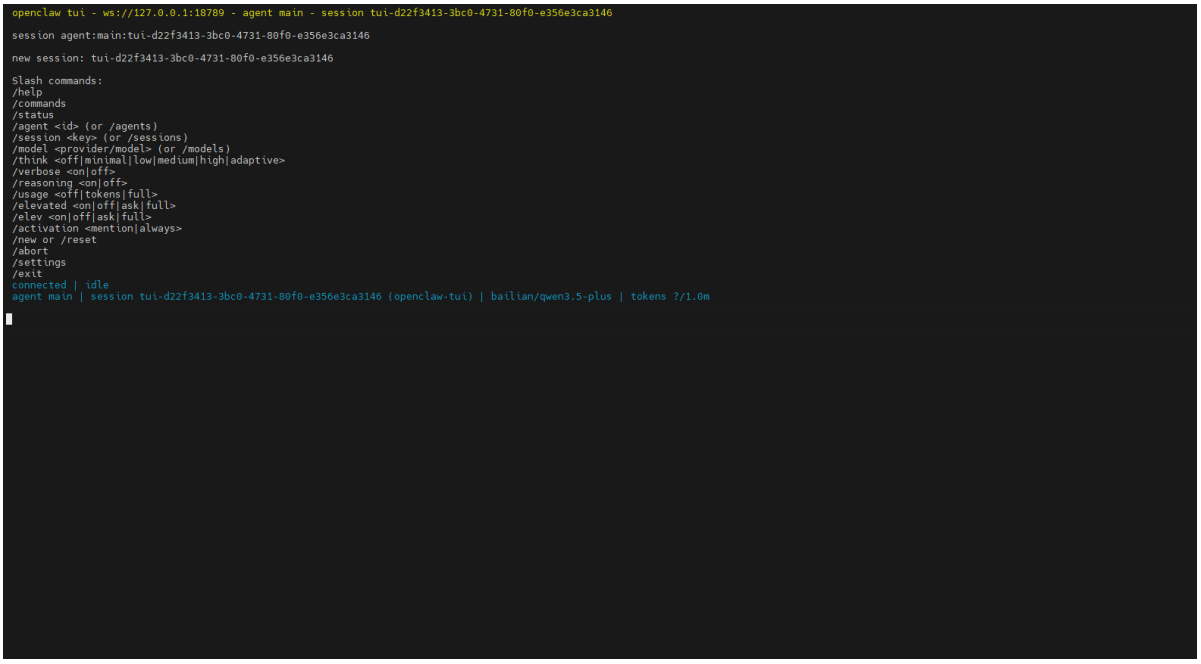
4. OpenClaw TUI Interaction

TUI (Text User Interface) is OpenClaw's "command-line chat window". When it is inconvenient to open the web console on the Jetson, or when you are connected remotely via SSH, you can use the TUI to complete most daily interactions in the terminal: dialogue, switching models, checking status, managing sessions, invoking skills, and so on.



1. How to Enter the TUI

Execute the following in the terminal:

```
openclaw tui
```

If you have already started the OpenClaw gateway in another terminal (for example, the gateway/server side), you can directly execute `openclaw tui` to enter the interactive interface

For the non-Docker version, openclaw gateway does not need to be started manually; it starts automatically at boot

For the Docker version (such as Jetson Nano), you need to open a terminal first and run openclaw gateway manually to start the gateway

2. What the TUI Interface Is

You can think of the TUI as a "chat box with commands":

- Top: dialogue history (messages you send, model replies, tool/skill output)
- Bottom: input box (enter questions or send slash commands)
- Sending: type the content and press Enter to send

It is recommended to do two things first when entering for the first time:

```
/status
```

3. Slash Commands

Slash commands generally need to be sent as a separate message starting with `/`, and are used to control sessions and run operations.

Command	Purpose	When to Use	Example
`/help`	View help and the command list	You do not know which commands exist	`/help`
`/status`	View the current status	You suspect it is not connected, or want to see context usage	`/status`
`/new`	Start a new conversation thread (new session)	Switching topics, avoiding context interference	`/new`
`/reset`	Reset the session (equivalent to starting over; same effect as new)	The dialogue goes off track, you want to clear the context	`/reset`
`/model` / `/models list`	View/switch models	You want a faster or stronger model	`/models list`
`/think medium`	Set the thinking depth	For daily use, low or off is recommended	`/think medium`
`/stop`	Abort the current task	It is stuck and you want to stop immediately	`/stop`
`/context detail`	View the context currently injected	Investigating "why it remembers/forgets something"	`/context detail`
`/compact`	Compress earlier history into a summary	The dialogue is too long and the context is nearly full	`/compact`
`/skill <name>`	Run a certain skill	You know the skill name and want to run it directly	`/skill web_search`

Two additional "everyday usage" suggestions:

- Write only one slash command per message; this is the most reliable
- To browse all commands quickly, use `/help` or `/commands`

4. Session and Memory

In OpenClaw, these two concepts have a clear division of labor:

- Session: manages "how far this conversation has progressed". When you use `/new` or `/reset` in the TUI, you are essentially switching/restarting the session.

- Memory: manages "content that should be retained long-term across sessions". It is written to disk (Markdown) and retrieved back into the current session when needed.

4.1 Where Session Files Are Located

Sessions are saved to disk in JSONL form. Common locations (subject to the actual installation path):

- Index: `~/.openclaw/agents/<agentId>/sessions/sessions.json`
- Transcript: `~/.openclaw/agents/<agentId>/sessions/<SessionId>.jsonl`

For actual troubleshooting, the easier approach is to execute the following first:

```
openclaw status
```

It usually provides the store path and information about recent sessions.

4.2 How Memory Is "Put to Use"

You can think of Memory as "letting the robot write notes":

- `memory/YYYY-MM-DD.md`: a daily record of the process, suitable for recording progress and temporary decisions
- `MEMORY.md`: long-term stable information (preferences, fixed rules, project constraints, etc.)

Practical suggestions:

- To make a conclusion usable across sessions: simply say to the robot "write this into MEMORY.md"
- Before using `/new` to switch to a new topic: first use `/compact` or write the key decisions into Memory, then switch the session

5. Quick Start Workflow

1. Enter the TUI: `openclaw tui`
2. Confirm the status: `/status`
3. Select a model: `/models list` → `/model <number or name>`
4. Daily dialogue: directly enter a question and press Enter
5. Switch topics: `/new`
6. Context too long: `/compact`
7. Key conclusions to keep long-term: have the robot write them into Memory

6. Common Troubleshooting

6.1 No Response After Entering a Command

- Make sure the command is sent as a separate line (do not mix it with ordinary text)
- First use `/help` to see which commands the current version supports

6.2 It Starts Talking Nonsense, Does Not Understand You, or Is Disturbed by History

- Start a new session: `/new` or `/reset`
- See what has been injected into the context: `/context detail`

6.3 Responses Are Getting Slower

- Lower the thinking depth: `/think low` or `/think minimal`
- Compress the history: `/compact`